



224

DEAD

400

WOUNDED

UNLEARNED LESSONS:
Help arrived late for the victims and the delay contributed to the high death toll

were not helped by the fact that the only ambulance was parked way below at the main entrance to the fort and it took an hour-and-a-half before it could weave its way through the melee. There was no power backup at the temple, no rescue and medical teams on standby and nor a crowd control mechanism in place. The medical facilities at the mishap site consisted of just one ambulance parked far away. It was equipped with nothing more than a basic first aid kit. After a short while and with the numbers of the wounded mounting, even the hospital ran out of medicines.

Religious festivals, often attended by thousands if not lakhs of pilgrims, are never the safest of places. The increasing incidence of such stampedes that have cost hundreds of lives in recent years raises serious questions about the organisation of such fairs (see box). In less than two months, over 300 of the devout have ended up court- ing death in places of worship. The tragedy is that these could have been avoided if authorities at some of the most popular shrines had learnt their lessons.

What happened at Jodhpur proves they have not. The temple is managed by the Maharaja Umed Singh Religious Trust and is headed by Gaj Singh, the erstwhile

maharaja. The fort and its surroundings as well as special festivals are managed by the Mehrangarh Museum Trust headed by Jaswant Singh, former finance minister. He refused to blame poor crowd management at religious places as the reason for such tragedies, saying security and controlling crowds at no two temples could be compared. "The need is for people enthused by devotion to show restraint as the deity is not going to disappear," he says.

In view of the serial blasts taking place across the country, the administration had taken steps to provide more forces to manage the navratra fair at the temple this year. One additional superintendent of police headed a party of an assistant SP, six inspectors and a 103-strong police force to maintain law and order. But the police and the private security guards employed by the trust proved to be inadequate.

On their part, the police had been on guard. At Chamunda Devi, devotees had always been segregated by separate queues for men and women along the 100-yard narrow path leading to the temple. But at around 5.15 a.m., sensing the enthusiasm in the crowd, particularly the young men, the authorities decided to open another route normally used by Maharaja Gaj Singh and

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